KESTREL-9

A derelict relay station for any science-fiction game. Three to five characters, one session.

Kestrel-9 was a crewed signal relay on the ice moon Tolla: six people, a mast, a drill. Eleven weeks ago its carrier signal changed to a slow, even pulse that matches nothing in the company's protocol book. Nobody has answered a hail since. The company wants the relay log and, if possible, an explanation it can put in a report.

WHAT HAPPENED

The glaciologist, Dr. Ines Maro, drilled into something under the station that pulses. The crew split over what to do. Four took the crawler and left; their tracks end at a crevasse two kilometers out. Maro stayed, and the engineer, Tobiah Rask, stayed with her. Rask rewired the mast to repeat the pulse. He is still here, living in the antenna shaft, and will not let the mast be shut down. Maro is in the lab, frozen into the drill pit up to her chest, and has been dead for weeks.

GETTING IN

The surface door into the airlock is the only way in that works. The garage ramp at the north end of the generator hall is sealed with a blast slab and buried in drift. The antenna shaft is open to the sky sixty meters up, for anyone who can climb an iced mast.

THE STATION

Everything is prefabricated: steel floors, ribbed wall panels, low ceilings except where noted. Corridors are two and a half meters wide. Power is on; heat is not. The sketch on the last page was drawn by the relief pilot from memory and is not to scale.

AREAS

1. AIRLOCK. Six meters by four. The outer door stands a hand's width open and is iced in place. Six suit lockers along the west wall, two of them empty. A bench. Boot prints in the frost lead north.

2. COMMON ROOM. About ten meters by eight: the middle of the station, with a door in every wall. A long table with six chairs, a galley counter along the north wall, a wall screen that shows the pulse as a green line. Four meals were left half eaten.

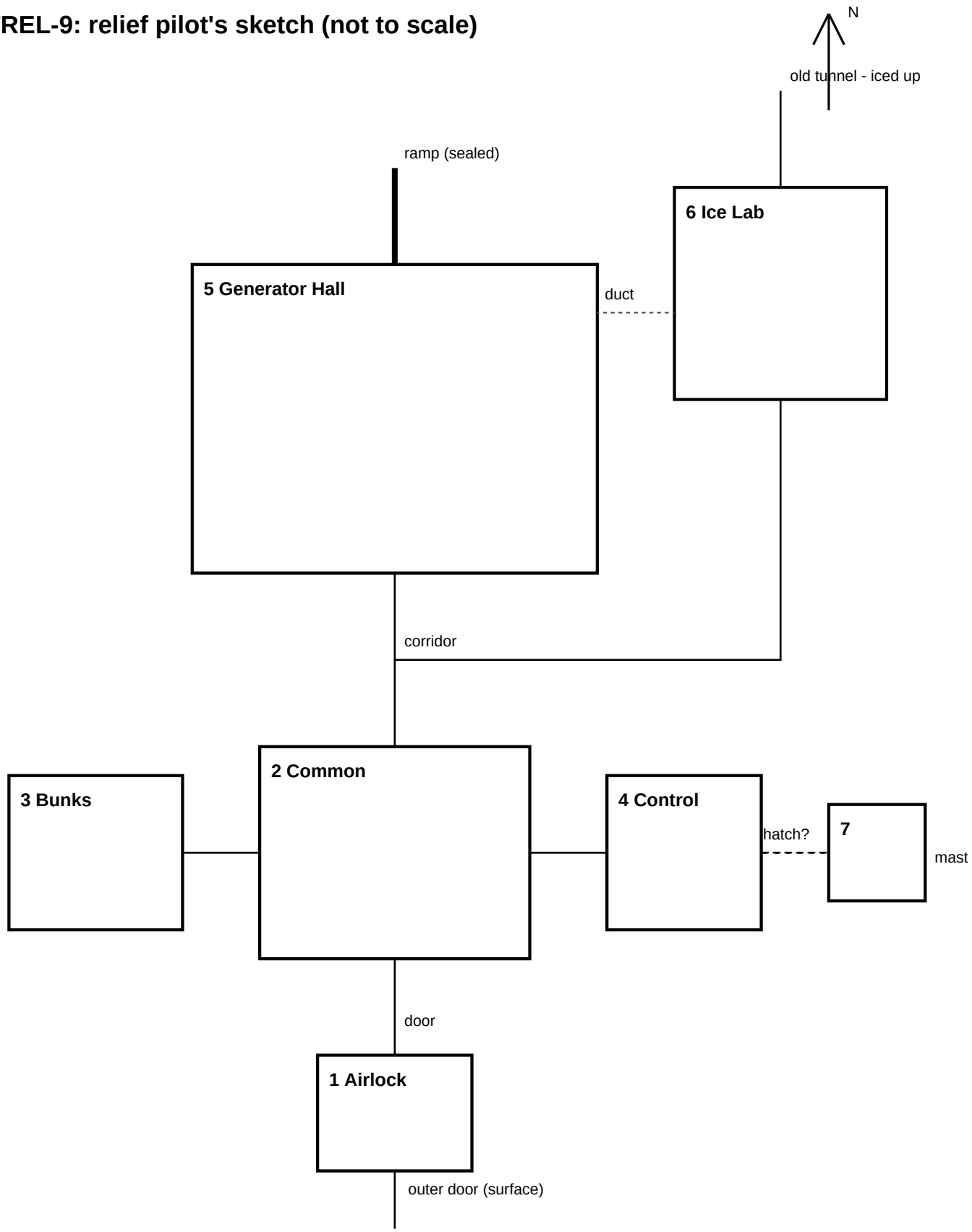
3. BUNKS. West of the common room. Three two-tier bunks and six lockers. One bunk has been stripped; its bedding is in area 7.

4. CONTROL. East of the common room. Two consoles and the relay rack. The log is here (what the company wants). Pulling the rack's master breaker stops the pulse, and brings Rask at a run. Behind the relay rack a maintenance hatch (the crew never mentioned it to the company; Rask uses it) opens on a short crawl east to area 7.

5. GENERATOR HALL. North of the common room, down a short corridor. The biggest space on the station, about eighteen meters by twelve and six high. Two generators side by side, a fuel tank on a cradle, a rank of fuel drums, a catwalk along the east wall. The garage ramp climbs out of the north wall and is sealed. A cable duct runs from the top of the east wall across to the lab (area 6); a thin person could crawl it.

6. ICE LAB. North-east: reached by the corridor that branches east off the generator hall corridor. Ten meters square. The drill rig stands over a round pit three meters across and eight deep, rimmed with warning paint. Core racks along the south wall. Dr. Maro is in the pit. The pit floor is black glass and it pulses. A tunnel once ran north from the lab to the old drill site; the roof came down and it is packed with ice.

7. ANTENNA SHAFT. East of control. A room four meters square at the foot of the mast, open to the sky far above. Rask's nest: bedding, ration tins, a heater that does not work. A ladder up.

IF THEY STAY TOO LONG (roll d6 every twenty minutes)
1-2. The pulse quickens. Everyone hears it in their teeth.
3. Lights fail in one area for ten minutes.
4. Rask watches from a doorway and withdraws.
5. Frost creeps: one door ices shut (strength test to force).
6. The pit answers the mast. Everything loose in area 6 slides a hand's width toward the pit.

KESTREL-9: relief pilot's sketch (not to scale)